



What do we know about government public relations (GPR)? A systematic review of GPR in public relations literature

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ABSTRACT

Despite the importance of public relations within local, national, and international government organizations, government public relations (GPR) is still an understudied field in public relations research when compared to its corporate and nonprofit counterparts and has been critiqued for lacking theoretical development (Liu & Horsley, 2007). To present the accumulated knowledge about GPR, this study used content analysis and bibliometric network analysis to systematically review 155 articles published in key public relations journals from 1976 to 2021. Our findings illustrate the status of GPR scholarship in terms of publication trends, authorship, research contexts, research topics, theoretical knowledge structure, methodological approaches, and ethical considerations. Findings suggest that GPR is a fast-growing field attracting international and multidisciplinary scholarly interests; yet has not been clearly defined and theorized. With strong theoretical roots in relationship management, GPR has the potential to develop context-relevant theories capturing the distinctive relational dynamics in various government communication situations. This study proposes a work-in-progress definition of GPR, identifies critical research gaps, and suggests future research directions to assist GPR in developing into a distinct and promising subfield of public relations research.

1. Introduction

Public relations plays an essential role in the public sector, providing a variety of communication and relationship management functions to government entities, such as public information (Graham et al., 2015), crisis and disaster response (Chen, 2009; Waymer & Heath, 2007), building national images (Taylor, 2000), citizen and community engagement (Lendingham, 2001), as well as defending, facilitating and sustaining social democracy (Waymer, 2013). This area of scholarship is known as government public relations (GPR), and it focuses on the value, function, and influence of public relations and communication in the public sector (Lee et al., 2021).

Research on public relations in the political context has had a long history, which can be traced back to 64 B.C. (Strömbäck & Kioussis, 2013). GPR has existed as a branch of public relations research for decades, receiving multidisciplinary academic interest from political communication, political marketing, political public relations, government communication, organizational communication, and public administration (Canel & Sanders, 2013; Dolea, 2012; Kioussis et al., 2019; Lee et al., 2021; Liu & Horsley, 2007; Sanders, 2019). Yet, despite

the importance of public relations within local, national, and international government organizations and multidisciplinary interest in GPR, GPR scholarship is underdeveloped compared to its corporate and nonprofit counterparts and has been critiqued for lagging in theoretical advancement (Liu & Horsley, 2007). Additionally, scholars argue that GPR research lacks a cohesive conceptualization and research identity due to multidisciplinary interests and overlaps with political communication and other cognate fields (Canel & Sanders, 2013).

GPR scholarship has grown rapidly in recent years, with scholars studying a wide range of public relations issues, such as disaster relief (Liu et al., 2018), strategic use of social media (Levenshus, 2016), COVID-19 pandemic (Gregory et al., 2021), and public diplomacy (Chang & Lin, 2014) in countries and regions worldwide, and employing a variety of quantitative, qualitative, and network methods. These findings indicate that GPR is evolving into an important body of public relations research deserving a deeper systemic understanding of its accumulated intellectual qualities. Yet, no systematic literature review of this subject is available from a public relations perspective. Developing a comprehensive analysis of the status quo of GPR scholarship is important for us to understand the research focus of GPR scholars, how

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their choices influence what we know about public relations in the public sector, and how we advise practitioners in communicating with a variety of publics they are tasked with caring for.

The current study performs a systematic literature review of 155 articles published in key journal outlets of public relations to reveal the prominent themes, contexts, methods, and ethical considerations studied in the GPR literature. Additionally, we adopt a knowledge construction framework to identify and track the patterns and connections of theories and concepts central to GPR research. This study is an early attempt to map the territory of GPR research as a subfield of public relations. We argue that GPR scholarship has great potential to establish its distinct identity further. Our findings identify the gaps in GPR research, offer insights on the future directions for GPR scholarship, and propose a working definition of GPR to help scholars advance this line of research and equip government communicators with a scholarly view to engage in their profession.

2. Literature review

2.1. Public relations in government

Public relations in the public sector has certain characteristics that set it apart from other public relations practices. As Liu et al. (2010) noted, the communication environment for GPR is inherently more complicated than that for the private sector, which is described by Liu and Horsley (2007) in terms of eight constraints, including politics, political superstructures or ideologies (federalism), legal restraints, public good, media scrutiny, devaluation of communication, poor public perceptions, and lagging professional development. Van der Wal (2020) described the complex environment of GPR as “VUCA,” known as volatile, uncertain, complex, and ambiguous. In addition, GPR fits unique communication purposes that are labeled by Lee et al. (2021) as mandatory, optional, and dangerous. The mandatory purposes of GPR are democratic, which integrates public relations into public administration through media relations, public reporting, and responding to citizens. Next, the optional purposes of GPR are to enhance the efficiency of public administration through strategic communication efforts, such as public education and outreach. And lastly, the dangerous goals of GPR are to secure stronger public support to increase government autonomy and minimize political interference from lawmakers and elected leaders.

Moreover, governments have distinct roles and responsibilities from the private sector (Hong et al., 2012). One of the most important aspects of GPR is publicness (Dolea, 2012). Unlike public relations in the private and nonprofit sectors, where economic or organizational rewards are a key motivation, government agencies serve public interests (Hong, 2013; Vandebosch, 2004), and this is particularly important when crises arise (Chon, 2019). Although government communication shares some attributions with corporations and employs a similar dialogical toolbox (Liu et al., 2010), there is a need to introduce government-centric variables into public relations. However, governments may not be able to cater to everyone's interests (Waymer, 2013), because GPR is multi-layered, operating at the international, national, and local levels to serve large and diverse publics (Levenshus, 2016; Liu et al., 2012; Rice & Somerville, 2013; Sanders, 2011), resulting in frequent conflicts and tensions.

Furthermore, politics and non-partisan, two contradictory concepts, are both stressed in GPR literature. GPR is inevitably influenced by political power and structure because GPR's goals, scopes, budgets, and personnel are restricted by elected politicians (Sanders, 2019), which may be against communicators' will when practicing public relations (Liu et al., 2012). For example, instead of merely evaluating professional abilities, political variables such as partisanship will be considered when selecting communication heads (Canel & Sanders, 2013). Although politics has never been divorced from government communication, some contend that public officials should be seen as public servants and

not as politicians (Glenny, 2008; Liu et al., 2010). Government communication should be neutral, informative, and autonomous of party politics (Russmann et al., 2020).

Recently, scholars in both public relations and public affairs have pointed out several trends in the communication profession that bring opportunities or challenges for GPR. First, social media and digital platforms have emerged as promising tools for GPR to bridge the information gap between government authorities and publics (Arshad & Khurram, 2020), improve government service delivery (Bertot et al., 2010), and facilitate civic engagement (Dong & Ji, 2018). Recent years have also seen studies investigating government social media use in extreme situations, such as disaster relief (Liu et al., 2018) and the Covid-19 pandemic (Chen et al., 2020; Islm et al., 2021). However, governments are still falling behind the private sector in utilizing the interactive and dialogic features of social media for a variety of reasons, such as legal constraints, the digital divide, and insufficient training (Falco & Kleinhans, 2018; Graham & Avery, 2013; Heaselgrave & Simmons, 2016; Levenshus, 2016). Given the prevalent use of social media among citizens and the abundance of digital platforms available for government-citizen engagement (Falco & Kleinhans, 2018), national and local government officials are constantly challenged by how to effectively approach diverse citizens, build online civic communities, and improve government transparency through social media and digital platforms (Graham & Avery, 2013; Wukich, 2022). Second, globalization increasingly demands public relations practitioners to adopt a multicultural perspective when communicating with international publics (L'Etang et al., 2007). As GPR is increasingly applied to national image branding and political agenda promotion (Yang, Klyueva, & Taylor, 2012; Lee & Jun, 2013), government officials are urged to critically assess their current values, roles, and impacts in building relationships with foreign publics. However, how to shift public diplomacy away from persuasion and propaganda and toward responsible, ethical, and relationship-oriented public diplomacy via public relations is a topic that requires more scholarly attention (Yang et al., 2017). In addition, since GPR is rooted in and shaped by the social and political system, an international perspective on how public relations is practiced across different social and political environments by governments is necessary to contribute to a critical and pluralistic view of GPR (Tantivejakul, 2019).

The current GPR literature has made significant contributions to portraying GPR characteristics and indicated an increasing need for more GPR research. However, a systematic review of peer-reviewed journal papers featuring government communication is absent, including from a public relations perspective. The theoretical, methodological, thematic, and contextual evolutions of GPR research remain largely unidentified, which poses obstacles to a comprehensive understanding of the current territory of GPR scholarship. To address this research deficit, we propose the following research questions:

RQ1: What are the main research trends of GPR scholarship, in terms of (a) publication pattern, (b) authorships/ institutions, (c) research themes, (d) research contexts (i.e., country of study, the level of government, and social media/digital platform), and (e) prominent publications?

2.2. Knowledge structure of GPR scholarship

Research in GPR has become more prominent over the years, with scholars like Taylor and Kent (1999) arguing that government is the most important public in a developing nation, and more recent work by Albishri et al. (2019) analyzing the agenda-building and mediated public diplomacy efforts of the Saudi and U.S. governments. Despite the rising and diverse study subjects in the GPR literature, it is still regarded as an undeveloped field of communication research (Sanders, 2019). GPR is an interdisciplinary academic research subject with interests in fields like political communication, political marketing, political public

relations, government communication, organizational communication, and public administration (Canel & Sanders, 2013; Dolea, 2012; Lee et al., 2021; Liu & Horsley, 2007; Sanders, 2019; Strömbäck and Kioussis, 2019). Each linked field contributes a key piece to the jigsaw puzzle of understanding GPR while also making it difficult to identify a distinct GPR study territory. According to Canel and Sanders (2013), government communication research is at a crossroads of research traditions in political communication and other related domains and has been unsuccessful in attempting to establish a distinct conceptualization and research identity. However, theoretical distinctions between GPR and multidisciplinary study topics remain ambiguous (Sanders, 2019).

Liu and Horsley (2007) scrutinized five dominant public relations models used in government communication literature and argued that the one-size-fits-all theories do not adequately account for the relational complexity and unique environmental constraints in the public sector. Thus, they presented the Government Communication Decision Wheel model, which encompasses government communication working in four microenvironments (intergovernmental, intragovernmental, multi-level, and external). However, this concept is centered on the U.S. context and needs more empirical validation in various government communication environments (Horsley et al., 2010; Liu et al., 2010). Additionally, Waymer (2013) has criticized the relationship management paradigm that dominates public relations scholarship for failing to reflect and handle conflicting public interests and contentious relationships with public in the pursuit of democracy. Lastly, Strömbäck and Kioussis (2013) are concerned about the disconnect between political public relations practice and theory, echoing others' arguments that transdisciplinary research efforts that include practitioners' perspectives are required to improve the relevance of theory development to the GPR (Pfau, 2008; Sanders, 2019).

Yet, despite the growing critiques of a lack of theoretical foundation, there has been no systematic attempt at analyzing the theoretical underpinnings of GPR scholarship. We have seen similar critiques and responses in dialogue (Morehouse & Saffer, 2018), engagement (Morehouse & Saffer, 2019, 2020), and crisis communication (Cheng et al., 2022) scholarship, among others, yet investigations into the infrastructure of GPR research remains unexplored. To strengthen this body of research and assist practitioners in practicing ethical and strategic communication, we must understand the theoretical underpinnings from which researchers are drawing.

2.3. Defining government public relations

Current research provides some direction to guide the quest for GPR conceptualization, but it is still fragmented and conflicting. Some consider GPR to be an important public administration tool focusing on public relations for the government, aiming to assist public administrators to achieve policy or legislative goals (Lee, M. 2021). In this view, public relations assists government institutions in meeting democratic requirements through activities such as managing media relations, public reporting, and interactions with citizens (Lee, 2021). Others focus on public information or communication campaigns as a key function of GPR, aiming to inform, persuade, or motivate behavior change in a widely varied audience (Kopfman & Ruth-McSwain, 2021). GPR campaigns, according to this viewpoint, are planned and structured communication activities aimed at pushing domestic or worldwide issue agendas (Taylor, 2000; Zhang & Cameron, 2003). Cutlip (1976) made one of the earliest efforts to define the role of GPR as information offered in an interlocking public informational system with media and other social institutions to "inform the public of constructive, the complex subject matter" in democratic societies (Cutlip, 1976, p. 6), which emphasizes the inextricable interconnection between GPR and news media. Taking a step away from the press agency model of public relations, Strömbäck and Kioussis (2011) offered a relational perspective to understand GPR in the context of political public relations, which is defined as:

"the management process by which an organization or individual actor for political purposes, through purposeful communication and action, seeks to influence and to establish, build, and maintain beneficial relationships and reputations with its key publics to help support its mission and achieve its goals" (Strömbäck & Kioussis, 2011, p. 8).

It is common to understand GPR under the umbrella of political public relations because public sector communication operates in a political environment (Sanders, 2019). However, Sanders (2011) argued that there should be a difference between government communication managed to meet a government's political goals and government communication managed to promote the common civic good. Following this argument, Sanders (2019) referred to Canel and Sanders (2012)'s work, suggesting that a broader scope of government communication purposes can be characterized as the

"area of practice and study of that usually managed communication directed to key publics and pursuing both political and civic purposes, carried out by executive politicians and officials working for public institutions with a political rationale. These institutions are constituted on the basis of citizens' indirect or direct consent and are charged to enact their will." (Sanders, 2019, p. 166).

Sanders (2019) advocated for a critical examination of the intertwined nature of political and government communication, claiming that current political communication follows the "West Wing approach" (p. 168), which focuses solely on chief executives (e.g., president) as key communicators, narrows the strategic purpose of government communication to electoral success, and overwhelmingly emphasizes power in influencing communication decisions.

Taken together, despite researchers recognizing the value of public relations research in understanding government communication and political public relations (Canel & Sanders, 2013; Strömbäck & Kioussis, 2011; Strömbäck and Kioussis, 2019), there is a lack of a unified definition of GPR, and the present research lacks a systematic knowledge of how GPR is understood under multidisciplinary influences when situated in public relations contexts. We must dig deeper to understand current conceptualizations of GPR along with the methodological approaches employed in GPR scholarship to understand how research trends inform what we know, how we know, and—if needed—what to adjust in our approach to research GPR to update the trajectory. Thus, we pose the following RQs concerning the knowledge construction of the GPR literature to understand how previous research has shaped our understanding of GPR.

RQ2a.: What key theoretical frameworks (or models) and concepts have been studied in GPR scholarship?

RQ2b.: What is the relationship between theoretical and conceptual frameworks in GPR scholarship?

RQ3.: How has GPR been defined in public relations journal articles?

RQ4.: What methodological approaches have been employed in GPR scholarship?

2.4. Ethical considerations in GPR

Ethics is central to relationship management theory and practices (Bowen, 2004; Fitzpatrick & Gauthier, 2001). However, as Bowen et al. (2016) argued, "ethics was assumed to be part of the process and never studied explicitly in relation to what factors precede, build, maintain, and sustain relationships between organizations and their strategic publics" (p. 9). Ethics is of paramount importance to GPR. Previous studies have pointed out numerous ethical issues in government communication related to propaganda, disinformation, asymmetrical communication, and accountability (Bowen & Zhu, 2019; Gelders & Ihlen, 2010; Kim & Shim, 2020; Lovari & Bowen, 2020). As Bowen and Lovari (2021) suggested, government communicators face unique and

complex ethical challenges because the subjects being communicated are critical and have profound impacts on millions of people, requiring public relations and public information officers to be well-prepared for making responsible decisions and dealing with various ethical dilemmas. In addition, governments have a long history of dissatisfying, marginalizing, and disenfranchising their stakeholders (Waymer, 2013), thus they are often seen as misleading, dishonest, and manipulative (Garland, 2021). Although public relations practitioners tend to distance themselves from propaganda and other contentious persuasion roles (Bakir et al., 2019), there is still debate in academia and industry about whether GPR is an ethical oxymoron, especially when communicating for political purposes (e.g., propaganda and spinning) (Levenshush, 2016). Furthermore, ethical government public relations is complicated when interpreting it from different ethical and moral approaches, such as utilitarianism, virtue, categorical imperative, Confucianism, and the ethics of care, each of which has pros and cons when applied to government communication (Bowen & Lovari, 2021; Bowen & Zhu, 2019; Dong & Morehouse, 2022). While researchers have presented principle-based ethical frameworks to investigate political communication decisions (Bowen & Zhu, 2019), few studies have systematically examined the discourse around ethics in GPR literature (Dong & Morehouse, 2022), leaving limited understanding of ethical concerns and challenges in the public sector and their saturation with the current GPR theory development. As a result, we ask:

RQ5: What ethical considerations have been studied in GPR scholarship?

3. Method

3.1. Sampling procedures

Following the guidelines of previous systematic literature review studies (Cheng, 2018; Lee & Yue, 2020; Wang & Dong, 2017), this study employed a three-step method to collect a comprehensive dataset. First, a list of 15 journals in public relations, communication, and public administration was developed, given these fields' strong relevance to GPR and public relations research (Cheng, 2018; Lee & Yue, 2020; Morehouse & Saffer, 2019; Wang et al., 2021).

Second, two search engines, Web of Science Core Collection and Scopus, were used for preliminary data collection, following the guidelines of previous studies (Cheng et al., 2022; Wirtz & Zimbres, 2018). We identified relevant articles published in the selected journals using the following criteria: (1) written in English; (2) full-retrieved and electronically accessible; (3) peer-reviewed articles instead of editorials or book reviews (Ji et al., 2021; Wang et al., 2021); and (4) containing government-related keywords, such as government, public sector, public relations, relationships, strategic communication, with different combinations, in either title, keywords, or abstract. In total, 415 articles were generated from the preliminary search as of December 31, 2021.

Two researchers read 69 papers together, focusing on the titles, keywords, and abstracts to identify whether GPR is the key research topic in the paper instead of merely being mentioned as a generic term. The researchers met and discussed inclusion and exclusion. After an intercoder reliability check with a random sample of 41 articles (Krippendorff $\alpha = 0.80$), discrepancies were discussed and resolved. The remaining articles were screened afterward, yielding the final sample of 155 articles from 12 journals for further content analysis (Table 1).

3.2. Data analysis

Content analysis and bibliometric network analysis were used to provide a comprehensive picture of GPR research. For the content analysis, previous studies (e.g., Cheng, 2018; Lee and Yue, 2020; Wang et al., 2021) informed the development of our codebook including the following categories: (1) article information; (2) research contexts; (3) research focus on social media or digital platforms, (4) theoretical

Table 1
Sample of Journals and Articles.

Journal	Frequency	%
<i>Public Relations Review</i>	91	59 %
<i>Journal of Communication Management</i>	19	12 %
<i>Journal of Public Relations Research</i>	17	11 %
<i>Public Relations Inquiry</i>	9	6 %
<i>Asia Pacific Public Relations Journal</i>	6	4 %
<i>Chinese Journal of Communication</i>	5	3 %
<i>Journal of Applied Communication Research</i>	2	1 %
<i>Journalism & Mass Communication Quarterly</i>	2	1 %
<i>Journal of Communication</i>	1	1 %
<i>Management Communication Quarterly</i>	1	1 %
<i>Communication Theory</i>	1	1 %
<i>Journal of Broadcasting & Electronic Media</i>	1	1 %
Total	155	100 %

Note. No result was found in three journals, namely, Atlantic Journal of Communication, Information Communication & Society, and Central European Journal of Communication

frameworks and key concepts; (5) definition of GPR; and (6) methodological approach. For the network analysis, co-citation and co-occurrence networks were conducted to map the intellectual construction of GPR scholarship.

3.2.1. Codebook and coding procedure

Article title, keywords, author numbers, author names, and each author's affiliation were manually identified and recorded as article information. Research context refers to where the main research inquiries and main data analysis were situated. Country of study was coded in one of the categories, along with the level of government. If the keyword "social media" or its related terms (e.g., Facebook, Twitter, Weibo, etc.) were reflected in the RQ & Hypotheses and main findings, the article was coded as having a research focus on social media, and the specific social media platform was typed. Core theoretical frameworks refer to theories explicitly discussed in the literature review/ the development of RQ & Hypotheses, playing an important role in guiding the development of research inquiries or explaining findings. A core theoretical framework was first coded as presence (1) or absence (0), and each core theoretical framework's name and accompanying citations were coded. Key concepts refer to the concepts that were explicitly measured or analyzed in an article. Although an article may mention concepts such as trust, credibility, or satisfaction, these terms were often mentioned as generic terms without clear conceptualization or operationalization and showed low relevance to the article's key research inquiries. Thus, we only manually copied and pasted key concepts that were clearly defined and explicitly measured or analyzed in the articles. The clear definition of GPR was coded as presence (1) or absence (0), indicating whether the term was clearly and explicitly explained or conceptualized. The definition statement, as well as associated citations, were coded if available. Research method was coded by asking if an article employed one or more of 16 methods (cf Morehouse & Saffer, 2019). Lastly, coders collected information on sample types and measures of key variables.

The first and second authors each read five articles to create the first draft of the codebook. A random sample of 10 articles was generated for coders' training and codebook refinement. A new randomized sample ($n = 16$) was then generated and coded independently by the two coders, which yield acceptable intercoder reliability, with Krippendorff's Alpha scores ranging from 0.77 to 1.00. The coders met, resolved the discrepancies, and modified the codebook before coding the rest of the data.

3.2.2. Bibliometric network analyses

This study employed two social network analysis techniques to further illustrate the intellectual structure of GPR scholarship, namely, the co-citation network and the co-occurrence network. Network data

was pre-processed using VOSviewer and visualized in Gephi. Node-level metrics, including degree centrality, betweenness centrality, and eigenvector centrality, were calculated to assess the level of importance of a node (Morehouse & Saffer, 2018; Ji et al., 2021). At the network level, density was measured to indicate the connectedness of a network (Ji et al., 2021).

3.2.3. Keyword co-occurrence network

To understand research themes (RQ1c), a co-occurrence network analysis was performed to identify the prominent clusters of keywords, visualizing the research topics frequently occurring in the sample. Authors' keywords are vital in scientific research because they give a standard language and a tool to capture the essence of research. By analyzing the connections between frequently occurring keywords in the literature, a keyword co-occurrence network seeks to comprehend the knowledge components and structure of a scientific field (Radhakrishnan et al., 2017; Santa Soriano & Valdés, 2021). A keyword co-occurrence network treats each keyword as a node and the co-occurrence is calculated by the number of times two keywords are listed together in publications. Frequently co-occurred keywords constitute clusters that are assumed to be similar in core research interests.

3.2.4. Theory/concept co-citation network

To further answer RQ2, we created a co-citation network by linking the core theoretical frameworks and key concepts analyzed in the articles. A theory/concept co-citation network is a two-mode network that examines how a theory and a concept are coupled in the same theoretical framework (Ji et al., 2021). The tie between a theory and a concept indicates that they are researched in couple by the same article (Aria & Cuccurullo, 2017), and the tie strength indicates the number of articles co-cited both the theory and the concept. The theory/concept co-citation network is useful to reveal the knowledge structure of GPR research.

4. Results

Fig. 1 shows the publication trend of GPR scholarship from 1976 to 2021. Prior to 2006, GPR research received less attention, but has experienced fast growth during the last decade with 53 articles published between 2011 and 2015. The last five years have also seen an increase in scholarly interest in this topic, with 45 articles published as of December 31, 2021. As shown in Table 1, the majority of the GPR literature was published in *Public Relations Review* (59 %). Notably, three of the 15 main public relations journals have not published much GPR research, demonstrating an overall insufficient focus on this topic among public relations scholars.

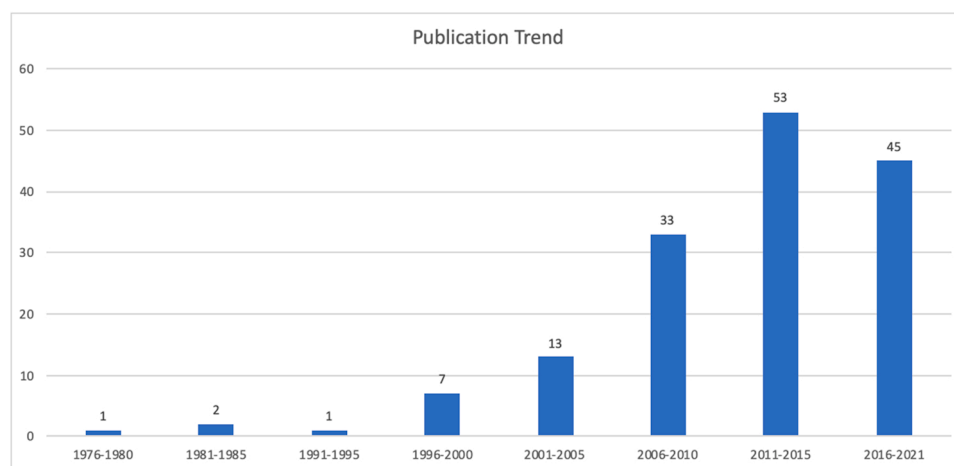


Fig. 1. The publication trend of government public relations research.

4.1. Authorship and institutions

Mordecai Lee, with 11 articles, was the most published author, followed by Spiro Kiouis (n = 6), Maureen Taylor (n = 5), Brooke Fisher Liu (n = 5), and Anne Geogory (n = 5). Top institutions were calculated by the cumulative article credit method (Pasadeo et al., 1999; Wang et al., 2021). The University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee was the institution with the most publications (n = 11, 11 credits), followed by the University of Florida (n = 8, 5.3 credits), University of Tennessee (n = 5, 3.5 credits), City University of Hong Kong (n = 4, 3.5 credits), and University of Maryland (n = 5, 3.3 credits).

4.2. Research themes

VOSviewer was used to visualize the research themes in a bibliographic network based on the keyword co-occurrence. Sampled articles (N = 155) were retrieved from the WoS and transformed into software-readable formats. All keywords (N = 439) were imputed to VOSviewer. As suggested by Cavalieri et al. (2021) and McAllister et al. (2021), the thesaurus file was used to manually merge and clean the duplicated keywords in plurals, abbreviated, or had other variations (e.g., public relations and public-relations). We set the minimum number of occurrences of 3 keywords, yielding 27 keywords to be included in the network. In general, the network density of keywords is .24 and the average connection between keywords is 6.22. One essential metric for describing the structure of the keyword co-occurrence network is the betweenness centrality of a node, which quantifies the number of times the node appears on the shortest pathways between any pair of nodes in the keyword network and indicates a node's influence within the network (Cheng, et al., 2018). According to the betweenness centralities, the most central keywords are "public relations," "government," "government communication," "crisis communication," and "social media."

Five clusters of research themes emerged from the keyword co-occurrence network can be characterized as 1) history of GPR, 2) international GPR, 3) political public relations, 4) crisis management, and 5) relationship management and social media (Fig. 2). Two authors qualitatively reviewed all the articles and provided detailed descriptions and summaries of each research theme, aided by the keyword clusters (Table 2).

4.3. Research context

GPR scholarship shows a strong international focus. More than half of the articles were conducted in non-US countries and regions (n = 90, 58 %). A small proportion of the sample (n = 8, 5 %) conducted cross-

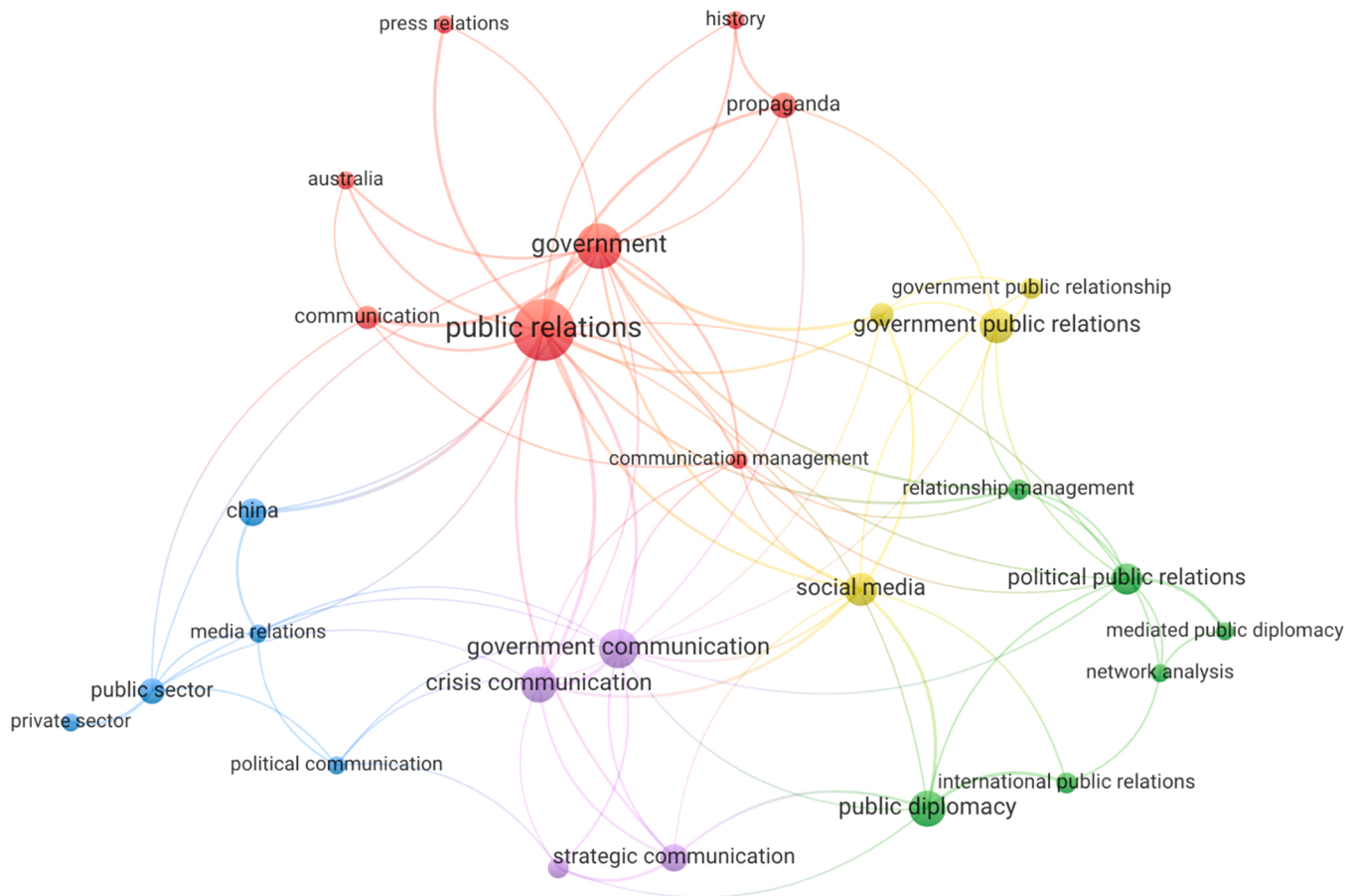


Fig. 2. Keywords co-occurrence network.

national analysis between the U.S. and other nations. In terms of the specific country, the U.S. was still the most researched country of GPR ($n = 58$, 37 %), followed by China ($n = 18$, 12 %), Australia ($n = 12$, 8 %), United Kingdom ($n = 11$, 7 %), and South Korea ($n = 8$, 5 %). Governments at the national/federal level attracted substantially more research interest ($n = 81$, 52 %), as compared to provincial/state ($n = 6$, 4%), and local ($n = 21$, 14 %) governments. A total of 17 articles studied multilevel governments (11 %, e.g., both local and level, see [Levenshus, 2016](#)), and nine articles examined cross-national and other types of governmental organizations (e.g., European Union, 6 %). A total of 23 articles regarded social media as a key topic (15 %). Facebook ($n = 13$, 30 %) and Twitter ($n = 16$, 36 %) were the two main social media platforms, followed by YouTube ($n = 3$, 7 %) and Pinterest ($n = 2$, 5 %). Vimeo, Flickr, and Google Plus were also mentioned ($n = 1$, 2 %, see [Graham et al., 2015](#)). Additionally, two Chinese social media platforms were examined, which are Weibo and WeChat.

4.4. Theoretical frameworks

The results showed that a total of 60 articles (39 %) explicitly presented at least one theory, model, or theoretical framework that is considered integral to research inquiries. The rest of the articles made no reference to core theoretical frameworks ($n = 95$, 61 %). Theoretical frameworks were adopted from multiple scholarly fields, such as public relations, mass communication, sociology, and organizational studies. For theories in public relations, relationship management ($n = 17$, 23 %), dialogical theory ($n = 7$, 9 %), Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT) ($n = 5$, 7 %), and Government Communication Decision Wheel (GCDW) ($n = 4$, 5 %) were most frequently applied. In terms of communication theories, the most often referred theories were agenda-

setting/building ($n = 6$, 8 %) and framing theory ($n = 5$, 7 %). In addition, social capital theory ($n = 3$, 4 %) was also applied to guide GPR research inquiries.

In addition to the core theoretical frameworks directly influencing research inquiries, we observed a total of 77 articles (50 %) mentioning a wide range of theories peripherally, such as relationship management, agenda-setting/building, excellence theory, contingency theory, attribution theory, Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT), Situational Theory of Problem Solving (STOPS), and Social-Mediated Crisis Communication (SMCC). Notably, almost half (50 %) of the articles made no reference to any theory at all.

4.5. Key theory/ concept co-citation network

To dive deeper into the intellectual construction of GPR scholarship, we generated the theory/key co-citation concept network to illustrate the linkages between theories and concepts addressed in the empirical articles of our sample. Core theoretical frameworks ($n = 17$) and key concepts ($n = 110$) that are explicitly measured or analyzed in the studies were coded. Theories and concepts with more than two connections were included in the network in [Fig. 3](#) to ensure their high relevance to research inquiries about GPR. At the network, the thickness of the edges presents the strength of relationships between theories and concepts, i.e., how many times the article examined the concept within certain theoretical frameworks.

Findings reveal that the network density is .08, suggesting that GPR theorization is relatively fragmented rather than with a specified theoretical focus. The average number of connections is 2.84, indicating that one theory/concept is related to two other theories/conceptions on average, illustrating relatively sparse connectivity among them.

Table 2
Descriptions of key research themes in GPR research from 1981–2021.

Research Themes	Description	Representative Articles
Historical analysis of government public relations	Studies describe and interpret government public relations practiced in a particular time or evolved from a historical perspective.	Anderson (2020) , Lee (2008) , Maartens (2016)
International government public relations	Studies focus on how government entities establish relationships with global audiences via public diplomacy and national branding (e.g., soft power).	Khalitova et al. (2020) , Taylor (2000) , Zhang et al. (2018)
Government crisis management	Studies examine how government entities face, cope with and rethink the risks, issues, and crises.	Graham et al. (2015) , Veil and Anthony (2017) , Zhao (2018)
Government-public relationship management and social media	Studies analyze the strategies used by government organizations to manage relationships with various publics, such as citizens, employees, media, non-profit organizations, and corporations and the impact of these strategies on relational outcomes, especially using social media.	Dong and Ji (2018) , Hong et al. (2012) , Levenshus (2016) , Liu et al. (2012) , Kim et al. (2015)
Political public relations	Studies examine how political figures, authorities, and institutions practice public relations through strategic communication activities.	Lee (2011) , Painter (2015) , Rice and Somerville (2013)

Theories ranked highest in degree centrality included relationship management (15), dialogue theory (10), and framing theory (7). These theories are considered key influencers that shape the theorization of GPR research, and they represent the current theoretical structure upon which the field has intellectually evolved.

As shown in [Table 3](#), relationship management was the most central theory in the network ([Fig. 3](#)). Key concepts related to this theory mostly serve as variables to evaluate the outcomes of organization-public relationships ([Dong & Ji, 2018](#)), such as trust, control mutuality, commitment, and openness (or satisfaction) ([Lan, 2018; Liu & Ni, 2021](#)). Also, for this theory, scholars in GPR studies examined diverse types of relationships, such as personal, professional, and community relationships ([Ledingham, 2001](#)). The most centralized concept is trust (5), coupled with five theories, namely, relationship management, dialogue theory, framing theory, SCTT, and social capital theory. Most articles highlight the important role of trust in developing, constructing, and maintaining relationships (e.g., [Lan, 2018; Painter, 2015](#)). From a social capital theory perspective, trust is regarded as one feature of social capital ([Sommerfeldt & Taylor, 2011](#)), measuring internal practitioners' trust relationship networks in government. However, only a few studies used trust as to indicate citizens' prior perceptions toward the government (e.g., [Liu & Ni, 2021; Paek & Hove, 2019](#)). In addition, framing theory was applied to investigate how trust was framed in government communications about particular issues (e.g., Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank) ([Lan, 2018](#)).

4.6. Methodological approaches

As shown in [Table 4](#), diverse methods were employed in GPR research. In general, more than half studies utilized qualitative methods (such as interviews, case studies, and historical studies). Approximately 17 % of studies used interview(s) ($n = 33$). Researchers often recruited

public relations practitioners as participants ($n = 32, 82\%$), and a few interviewed journalists ($n = 4, 10\%$) and citizens ($n = 3, 8\%$). As for quantitative methods, survey was most frequently used ($n = 34, 18\%$), and citizens ($n = 17, 50\%$) and public relations practitioners ($n = 15, 44\%$) were the most surveyed samples. Quantitative content analysis was the third most popular ($n = 27, 14\%$), analyzing government-related documents ($n = 12, 34\%$), newspapers ($n = 11, 31\%$), governmental websites ($n = 7, 20\%$), and social media posts ($n = 5, 14\%$). Historical analysis ($n = 24, 13\%$) and case studies ($n = 24, 13\%$) were also used to study historical and governmental documents, such as memories, diaries, and speeches of public people (e.g., [Larsson, 2012; Lee, 2008](#)).

4.7. GPR definition

Although all the papers in our sample directly addressed some GPR problems, only six papers explicitly discussed definitions of GPR. The easiest definition of GPR is proposed by [Cutlip \(1976\)](#) who stated that “government public relations is a weapon of power but the very nature of government makes public information operations essential if the media are to cover government effectively and economically” (p. 5). Both [Gelders and Ihlen \(2010\)](#) and [Kim and Cho \(2019\)](#) cited [Vandebosch's \(2004\)](#) definition, suggesting that GPR are “communication efforts in which the government/administration tries to be non-partisan, balanced and concise” (as cited in [Gelders & Ihlen \(2010\)](#), p. 60). [Tantivejakul \(2019\)](#) also argued that GPR differentiates from political communication in its nonpartisanship and “publicness,” emphasizing public access to open and transparent information. [Dolea \(2012\)](#) cited [Grunig \(2008\)](#) who stressed the managerial function of GPR, arguing that “government public relations focuses on the use of public relations by public institutions in order to advance their mission and achieve their goals” (p. 355). [Liu et al. \(2012\)](#) cited [Lee \(2008\)](#)'s argument that GPR is a public administration function that has four distinct objectives, including media relations, public reporting, outreach, and increasing public support.

4.8. Ethical considerations

While ethics is not a primary focus of existing GPR studies, ethical issues have been raised and discussed, at least briefly, in at least 40 articles. Some scholars have emphasized the importance of developing GPR as a principled profession with more rigorous and systemic ethical guidelines ([Ayish, 2005; Kirat, 2006](#)). Several theoretical frameworks and concepts were deemed ethical imperatives in defining ethical GPR. For example, [Bashir \(2019\)](#), [Gregory \(2008\)](#), [Kim \(2018\)](#), and [Storie \(2017\)](#) suggested that transparency is an important indicator of ethical public relations, given that it emphasizes open, honest, and accountable government communication. Dialogic and two-way symmetrical communication are regarded as more ethical than one-way communication since they foster a democratic and respectful communication process in which varied interests may be expressed and contentious issues can be discussed ([Glenny, 2008; Girona & Xifra, 2010; Heaselgrave & Simmons, 2016; Kang et al., 2018; Lane, 2018; Pètersone, 2013; Taylor & Kent, 1999; Yang, 2018; Zhang et al., 2004](#)). In contrast, manipulating relationships (e.g., guanxi) ([García, 2014](#)) and propaganda ([Dhani et al., 2015](#)) are considered unethical. However, ethical GPR faces obstacles due to the sensitivity and complexity of the communication topic (e.g., vaccination) ([Dimitrov, 2021](#)), the influence of politics and bureaucratic organizational structure ([Tantivejakul, 2019](#)), skeptical publics ([Wise, 2015](#)), and the absence of systematic professional ethical guidelines ([Tantivejakul, 2019](#)).

5. Discussion

Given the expanding importance of public relations in the public sector and the growing research interest among public relations

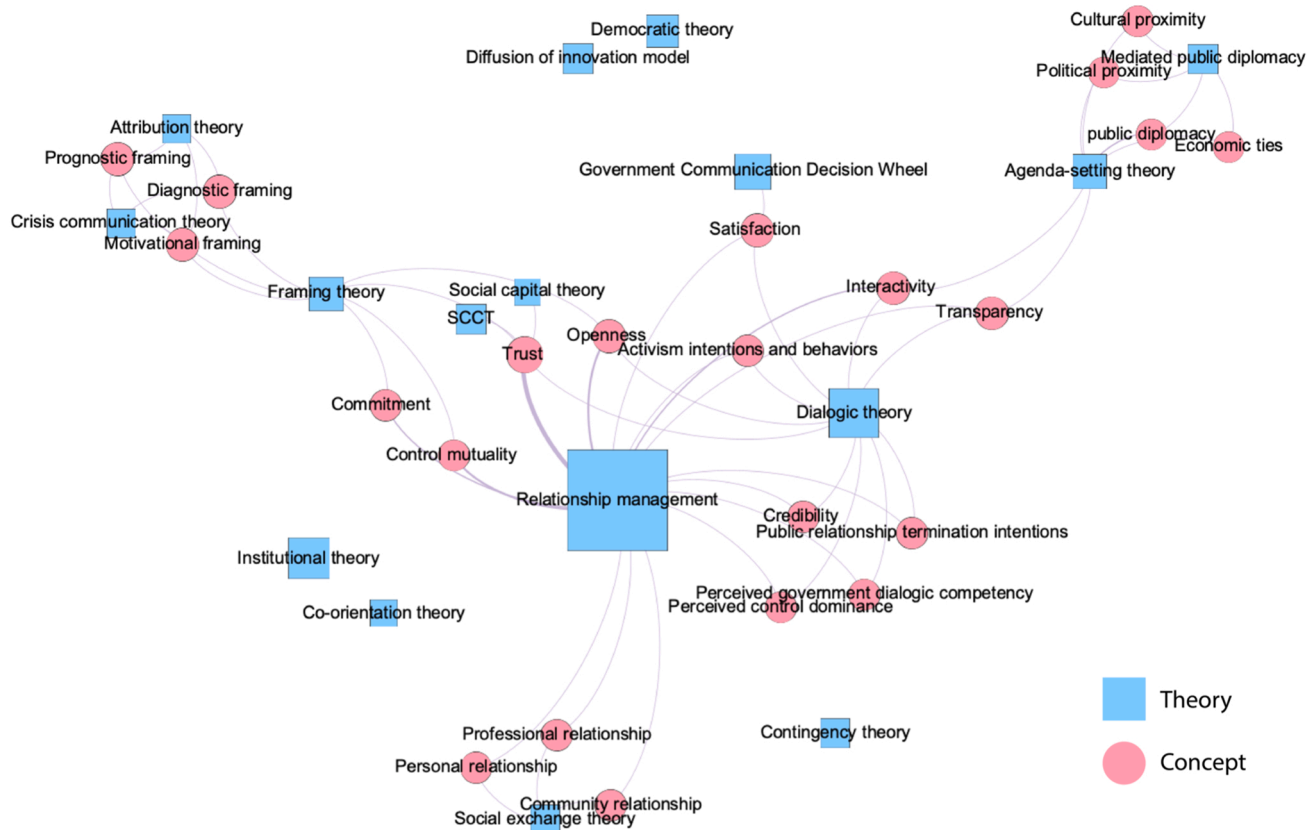


Fig. 3. Theory/concept co-citation two-mode network. Note. Individual nodes with degree centrality ≥ 2 are visualized in the Figure. Tie strength indicates the number of times a theory and concept is co-cited.

Table 3
Top 16 Cited Theory/Key Concept Network (Based on Degree Centrality).

	Count	Degree Centrality	Betweenness Centrality	Eigenvector Centrality
<i>Theory</i>				
Relationship management	12	15	279	1
Dialogic theory	4	10	99.33	0.75
Framing theory	2	7	141.83	0.39
Agenda-setting/building	4	6	138.33	0.25
Mediated public diplomacy	1	4	3	0.09
Social exchange theory	1	3	1.50	0.14
Attribution theory	1	3	1	0.10
Crisis communication theory	1	3	1	0.10
<i>Concept</i>				
Trust	8	5	102.33	0.47
Transparency	2	3	75.67	0.40
Interactivity	3	3	75.67	0.40
Openness	3	3	41.33	0.43
Satisfaction	1	3	31.67	0.36
Diagnostic framing	1	3	19	0.14
Prognostic framing	1	3	19	0.14
Motivational framing	1	3	19	0.14

Note. Numbers in the table match network parameters in Fig. 3. Count indicates the number of articles in which the theor or concept is identified.

scholars, this study presents a systematic analysis of 155 articles

Table 4
Methods used in government public relations research.

Method	Frequency	%
Survey	34	18 %
Interview (s)	33	17 %
Quantitative content analysis	27	14 %
Historical analysis	24	13 %
Case study	24	13 %
Qualitative or textual analysis	18	10 %
Literature/theoretical review	8	4 %
Network analysis	5	3 %
Experiment	3	2 %
Conceptual piece/essay	3	2 %
Rhetorical analysis	3	2 %
Ethnography/participant observation	3	2 %
Focus group(s)	2	1 %
Systematic Literature Review	1	1 %
Other	1	1 %

Note. Others include one method named genre analysis. Some methods in the codebook that are not employed in the sample include teaching module and meta-analysis. If an article is identified using multiple methods, each method coded separately.

published in prominent public relations journals from 1976 to 2021 to highlight key features of GPR research, identify critical research gaps, and recommend future directions for GPR research and practice.

Overall, the significant increase in publications reflects the growing relevance and significance of public relations in the public sector. GPR research has begun to draw the attention of public relations scholars since the 1970 s, and this body of literature has experienced fast growth in the past decade. More than half of the GPR literature is published in

Public Relations Review, suggesting the journal's prominent role in promoting this research subject, but also implying the low recognition of this body of research among other major public relations journals. Data also reveal a broad range of topics researched in GPR, covering historical, international, political, strategic, and relational perspectives, suggesting a pluralistic view on how public relations is pertinent to the existence, functions, and impacts of government entities. The variety of research topics underlines the complexity of GPR, emphasizing its potential for advancement into a distinct subfield of public relations scholarship.

Despite the growing scholarly interest, GPR is still at the early stage of constructing its own knowledge structure under the broad theoretical framework of public relations. Only 39 % of the GPR studies in our sample employed solid theoretical frameworks to guide or explain key research inquiries, exhibiting a less theory-driven research approach when compared to other emerging public relations topic areas, such as internal communication (Lee & Yue, 2020, 58 %), social media-related public relations (Wang et al., 2021, 58 %), social-mediated crisis communication (Cheng et al., 2022, 74 %), and social media in public relations (Roth-Cohen & Avidar, 2022, 66.26 %).

Results from the key theory and concept co-citation network also indicate the immaturity of GPR theory development. Theoretical and conceptual frameworks frequently referenced in GPR studies are predominantly well-established frameworks adopted from public relations and mass communication research, such as relationship management, dialogue, and framing (Lane, 2018; Ledingham, 2001; Rim et al., 2014). While it is fair to concentrate on these theories and concepts due to their importance to the relational nature of GPR and strategic GPR, these theories were not designed to explain GPR. The current GPR literature has not adequately created, changed, or expanded current public relations and communication theories to account for the particular contextual characteristics and problems of public relations in the public sector.

Methodologically, although both quantitative and qualitative methods were applied, most current GPR literature relied on qualitative, descriptive, or historical data. Empirical evidence on how GPR should work to achieve organizational, relational, and societal outcomes is needed to provide practical implications for strategic GPR activities. In addition, although case studies help construct nuanced and in-depth analyses, GPR research could benefit from more diverse and innovative methods, such as experiments and network analysis, to investigate causal relationships and macro-level analysis of GPR-related variables, thereby enhancing the generalizability of the findings.

Based on the findings from the systematic literature review, we identify five areas that are understudied in GPR and propose recommendations and directions for future research.

5.1. Building contextualized theories for GPR

Despite government organizations practicing public relations for centuries and public relations scholars studying this practice for decades, theoretical development in the GPR literature is fragmented and limited. Scholars primarily view GPR through the lens of the relationships that governments cultivate with their constituents, but only 17 articles out of the 155 included in this study included relationship management theory. Overall, this suggests a deep void in theorizing in the GPR literature. Thus, GPR scholarship is in a theoretical quandary that requires a twofold approach.

First, scholars looking to assist in the maturation of the GPR literature need to apply traditional public relations theories to the public sector. While this approach has been critiqued because "existing public relations models provide one-size-fits-all approaches to understanding public relations practice," we must understand the nuances of how strategic communication in government organizations is theoretically similar and different when compared to nonprofit and for-profit organizations' public relations efforts (Liu & Horsley, 2007, p. 391). Based

on the existing studies comparing government and corporate public relations practices (e.g., Liu et al., 2012; Park, 2003; Schultz & Raupp, 2010), future research may further theorize GPR using the existing evidence and continue identifying areas of differentiation for the practice of GPR in many contexts, including local, national, and international, which will ultimately bolster public relations and GPR theorizing overall.

Second, scholars need to propose dedicated public relations theories, concepts, and models for the public sector (cf. Liu & Horsley, 2007). Few scholars are stretching beyond the theoretical and conceptual bounds in the OPR scholarship to propose frameworks specific to the study and practice of GPR, and this second step is necessary to understand and account for the unique characteristics of public relations practice in the public sector (Liu & Horsley, 2007). This proposition is unique to the GPR literature when compared to other subfields in public relations scholarship (e.g., engagement, dialogue), yet this study is not the first to identify the need for context-specific frameworks to account for the peculiarities and idiosyncrasies of communication in the public sector (Liu & Horsley, 2007; Waymer, 2013). To mature this body of scholarship, it is necessary to evolve past atheoretical historical accounts or assessments of a government branch's activity on social media, and instead begin to test, refine, and analyze new and relevant theoretical and conceptual frameworks. To do so, scholars can take an interdisciplinary approach and marry public sector/administration theories, ethical theories, or other relevant theoretical frameworks with public relations concepts to propose new GPR frameworks, or follow the precedent set forth by scholars like Liu and Horsley (2007) and Waymer (2013).

5.2. What is GPR? Seeking a definition of GPR

Despite the diversified research themes in GPR literature, a clear and consistent conceptualization of GPR is still lacking, as only six studies in our sample explicitly defined the term yet show varying understandings of the nature of GPR. Many studies see the government or public sector only as a context for generic public relations activities like information dissemination, campaigns, and social media engagement (Anderson, 2018; Lee, 2011; Liu & Ni, 2021). However, more elaboration is needed on how these public relations activities may have altered their characteristics to fit in the context of government communication. Public relations was treated as an ancillary tactic serving the political or administrative goals of the government (Kim & Yang, 2008; Searson & Johnson, 2010). The murky conceptualization would impede the advancement of GPR scholarship as it neglects the unique organizational characteristics and environmental factors shaping public relations practices in government entities, which are distinctive from corporate public relations (e.g., Liu et al., 2010). By emphasizing the unique characteristics, functions, values, qualities, and impacts of public relations on government organizations, a definition of GPR will serve as a conceptual explanation for the research scope or boundary of GPR, distinguishing it from related fields such as political communication, government communication, public administration, and public affairs. Our findings on the key research themes and theoretical frameworks of GPR scholarship offer a starting point to develop a work-in-progress definition for GPR:

GPR refers to government organizations' non-partisan strategic communication and relationship management efforts to inform, interact with, influence, and protect diverse domestic and international publics in order to advance democracy, serve public goods, defend human rights, and ethically gain public trust and support under normal and extreme circumstances.

Compared to Canel and Sanders' (2012) definition as cited in Sanders (2019) that characterizes GPR as executive communication with both political and civic rationales, our definition centers on the

relational nature of GPR, given that relationship management is the most prominent theoretical framework guiding scholarly inquiries in the GPR literature. This definition also emphasizes GPR's multifaceted nature, considering the diverse publics it serves, the various functions it has, and the circumstances in which it is implemented (Waymer, 2013). Furthermore, while this definition acknowledges that GPR and political public relations share the common ground of being strategic and purposeful communication, it emphasizes "non-partisan" as a key feature distinguishing GPR from political public relations (Canel & Sanders, 2013; Gelders & Ihlen, 2010), which moves GPR away from the political interests that drive government organizations to establish, build, and maintain "beneficial relationships and reputations with its key publics" (Strömbäck & Kioussis, 2019, p.11) to embrace more public- and society-orientated relationship purposes. However, we believe that arriving at a holistic definition of GPR is an iterative process that still needs more academic attention and insights from diverse publics, government practitioners, and other GPR stakeholders.

5.3. Diversify GPR research contexts

There is evidence of considerable global interest in the literature, with various interpretations of context-specific GPR practices. Nonetheless, in previous studies, developed countries and large economies garnered the most research attention (e.g., the U.S., China) (Lee, 2011; Zhao, 2018). Only a few studies examined government-citizen relationships under non-US-centric ideologies such as in the Middle East and African countries (e.g., Albishri et al., 2019; Madichie & Hinson, 2014). While the larger focus on international contexts in the GPR literature is a positive trend, the primary focus on GPR practiced within developed countries is inaccurately narrow. The focus on developed countries and large economies in GPR scholarship not only impedes our understanding of how various countries, societies, and cultures practice public relations but also contains theory building and the ways in which public relations educators prepare the next generation of professionals to meet the growing challenges and needs of governments cultivating relationships and communicating with publics embedded within different countries and cultures (Sriramesh & Verčič, 2001).

To further acknowledge public relations' services to a pluralistic society, the research context must be expanded to include non-western, developing, and/or religious countries, among others. Additionally, the multilayer characteristics of GPR (Hosley et al., 2010) have not been thoroughly investigated in the literature studied, as state and local administrations received far less scholarly attention than the national/federal government. We argue that local governments, in particular, offer a rich opportunity to advance GPR scholarship as their closeness to local communities creates unique relational dynamics to revisit the current relationship management framework (Dong & Ji, 2018; Kim & Cho, 2019; Ledingham, 2001). Additionally, the majority of GPR studies focused on external publics. Government employees' and government communicators' perspectives are largely missing (Graham, 2014). To capture a full spectrum of publics' perspectives on GPR, future research may consider expanding the focus of government-public relationship management research to include internal publics within the inter or intra-government microenvironments (Liu & Horsley, 2007; Liu et al., 2010).

5.4. GPR on social media and digital platforms

We observed that social media has not gained sufficient attention in the GPR research compared to other subareas of public relations (Roth-Cohen & Avidar, 2022). Social media is generally recognized as an effective and innovative communication tool in government communication (Gregory et al., 2021), a useful channel for political campaigns (Painter, 2015), and a space to build online communities (Olsson & Eriksson, 2016). In contrast to the two-way symmetrical communication model recommended for the corporate and nonprofit use of social media

(Grunig, 2008; Lovejoy & Saxton, 2012), GPR reconciles the asymmetrical mode of one-way communication (Pan, 2020). However, as Waters and Williams (2011) argued, the employment of one-way communication on social media is not because government communicators lack professional sophistication, but more of a strategic decision given the complexity of GPR. Empirical studies concerning publics' perceptions are, in particular, limited in GPR literature. Yet, current research has not provided enough rationale for the adoption of social media strategies, especially from government practitioners' perspectives. Although previous research (Dong & Ji, 2018; Hong, 2013) has examined citizens' usage of social media to connect with governments as predictors of the quality of government-citizen relationships, the technological affordances of social media/digital platforms have received insufficient attention in terms of their functions in meeting a plethora of GPR needs, which calls for more empirical research.

5.5. Develop ethical frameworks of GPR

Our findings reveal indicators of ethical and unethical GPR (e.g., transparency vs. manipulation), theories/models representing ethical GPR (e.g., dialogue, two-way symmetric), and challenges of ethical GPR (e.g., issue complexity). However, a normative ethical framework for GPR has yet to be saturated in the current literature. We echo Bowen and Zhu (2019) to suggest that both normative and systematic ethical frameworks should be developed to guide the GPR process and performance evaluation. We propose the following ways of advancing the ethical frameworks for GPR. First, future GPR research should find the common ethical challenges shared with the corporate and nonprofit sectors and apply existing ethical frameworks of public relations (Bowen et al., 2016; Formentin & Bortree, 2019; Pearson, 2017) to various government communication circumstances in order to establish consistent professional codes of ethics for GPR. Second, to develop contextualized guidelines for GPR ethics, we suggest more research on the antecedents and consequences of ethical GPR behaviors. Based on the results from our systematic review, future research may examine empirically how different segments of publics perceive GPR ethics in terms of rhetoric/persuasive discourse (Rice & Somerville, 2013), symmetrical communication (Zhang et al., 2004), transparency (Gelders & Ihlen, 2010; Storie, 2017; Yang, 2018), and openness (Zhang et al., 2004), and how these ethical communication factors affect publics' identity (Gilpin et al., 2010), community engagement (Heaselgrave & Simmons, 2016; Kim & Cho, 2019), and government trust (Hong, 2013), thereby justifying the process and impact of ethical GPR.

5.6. Limitations

While rigorous in its approach, this study is not without limitations. First, the researchers collected and examined journal publications in English, which risks the bias of a westernized interpretation of GPR. Given the global scope of GPR studies as indicated in our sample, future research should consider incorporating non-English journals into the analysis. Second, our analysis only focused on peer-reviewed journals. Future research can broaden the scope of analysis by acknowledging the intellectual contributions from books and book chapters (e.g., Lee et al., 2021; Strömbäck & Kioussis, 2019) and professional organizations (e.g., NAGC, PRSA) to GPR research. It is important to clarify that by emphasizing the potential for GPR to develop into a significant domain of public relations, we are not advocating for its separation from related disciplines (e.g., political public relations). Rather, this study lays the groundwork for GPR scholars to confirm the convergence with other areas of public relations research, carve out a strategic niche within the broader field of communication, and articulate its unique contributions to a more ethical and socially conscious approach to public relations. Future research may move beyond our findings within the field of public relations to further investigate GPR systematically in interdisciplinary literature.

6. Conclusion

This study performed a systematic review of 155 GPR studies published in public relations journals. Using content analysis and bibliometric analysis, we found patterns and trends in GPR research and illustrated the theoretical territory of GPR scholarship. Given its diverse research topics, theoretical linkage to relationship management, and relevance to other significant public relations topics and concepts, we conclude that GPR is a burgeoning subfield of public relations research. However, as compared to corporate and nonprofit public relations studies, GPR is still in its infancy in terms of coherent conceptualization and contextualized theory building. The existing GPR literature does not sufficiently build, adapt, or extend current public relations and communication theories to account for the specific contextual features and issues. To advance this line of research, we proposed a definition of GPR and suggested that more scholarly attention be paid to developing GPR theoretical frameworks, incorporating diverse government communication contexts, investigating social media strategies appropriate for governments, and developing a GPR code of ethics. Our results and future study approaches may help GPR scholars polish research identity and agenda, define unique GPR values and contributions, and elevate this line of research into a distinct subfield of public relations.

Conflict of interest

All authors confirm that this manuscript has not been previously published and is not currently under consideration by any other journal or conference. Each author has approved the contents of this paper and has agreed to the submission policies of PRR. No funding support was received from internal and external institutions for this study.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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